

Breaking the Barrier

This first novel that tells the story of three women of Indian descent in a Cambridge charity shop rises above the usual chick-lit fare



THE CAMBRIDGE CURRY CLUB
by SAUMYA BALSARI
BlackAmber/Arcadia Books
Price: Rs 275
Pages: 244

■ By Brinda Bose

It's set in Cambridge, but it has nothing to do with the university. It's called the Curry Club but it really doesn't do much with that hot and spicy dish that is supposedly India's signature culinary tune across the globe. It's about four women and their travails on a single day at work, but it's not your usual chick-lit.

There is something off-beat and intriguing about Saumya Balsari's debut play-turned-novel—just enough to keep you turning the pages, and yet, not quite enough to make it unputdownable. So does it disappear between those cracks? Not quite. Balsari breezes through her tale: she has a light and deft pancake-flipping touch (as opposed to a languorous curry-ladling one) as she dishes up her four protagonists, three different women of Indian descent and one Irishwoman, who volunteer on Thursdays at a charity shop called IndiaNeed on Mill Road in the heart of Cambridge's "town" (as

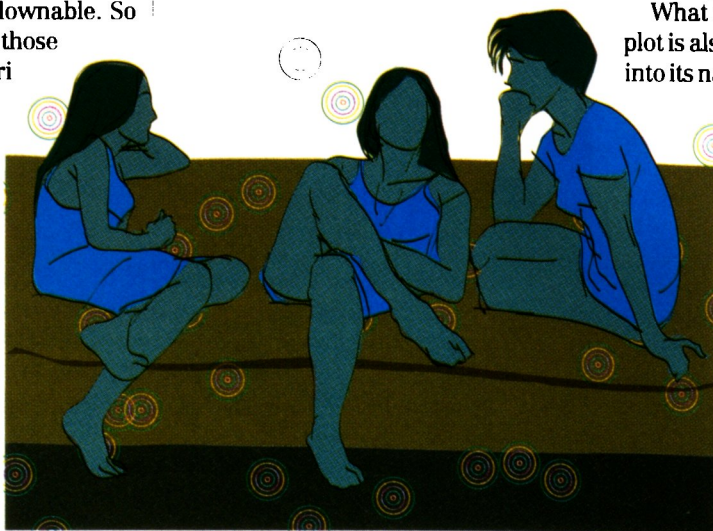
opposed to its "gown") quarters.

With felicitous twists of phrase and twirls of quirky humour, Balsari brings her women to life: the middle-aged Heera Malkani Moore, who manages the store and her English husband Bob while still secretly yearning for her teenage sweetheart Javed; the prudish Bengali housewife Swarnakumari who washes her palms and utters prayers to her Guru Ma with equal fervour; the ex-mathematics teacher Eileen who suffers Catholic pangs of guilt for others' sins but recovers her equilibrium in sudden surprising spurts of Irish optimism; the intellectual Durga who brings youthfulness and academic jargon to fall gently among the bric-a-brac. Presiding over these women, mainly in absentia and substantially as a disembodied

voice on the telephone, is IndiaNeed's haughty benefactress Lady Diana Wellington-Smythe who, true to her colonial-throwback persona, can neither remember nor pronounce the Indian women's names and suspects them of stealing from donations that are dumped daily at the shop's door.

On the day that we get to spend with these ladies, everything that can possibly go wrong, does. The novel exposes its theatrical origins in its sitcom-like structure, stringing together a series of farcical episodes that the ladies must manoeuvre all in a day's work—the arrival of a refugee from a proposed honour-killing, an old lady who dies in a corner of the shop, love trysts that threaten to go awry, and a robber whose identity gives the women a tempting chance to deal their boss a ponderous blow. (Balsari's tale began as a successful stage performance that was converted into a novel at the request of an adventurous publisher.) When the roof (literally) falls down on the shop at the end of the day, it's merely a whimper, and not a bang.

What redeems this slight-sounding plot is also what is not well-integrated into its narrative—interspersed chapters that provide histories of its four women, creating an engrossing ambience for their antics. Balsari flaunts promise in fits and starts, curiously mimicking one's fluctuating fortunes when one bargain-hunts in a typical British charity shop. And those readers who have been there and done that will know that this is not an uncharitable comment in the least.



SAURABH SINGH

NEW RELEASE



MARIO DE MIRANDA
Edited by GERARD DA CUNHA
Architecture Autonomous
Price: Rs 2,700
Pages: 284

For Mario de Miranda, everything in life is funny—be it cats, trees, human figures, doing everything from speaking to smoking or even just sitting idle. He captures the mood and the style with élan. This book is a

compilation of his work as an illustrator, cartoonist and documenter of life as he perceives it. Gerard da Cunha has put this voluminous book together by searching for his work from friends, collectors and from Mario himself. Mario's versatile work made it difficult for da Cunha to choose and organise the book. The book is divided into various sections—Diaries (1947-1951), The Times Group (1953-1977), Pocket Cartoons (1990-2005). He travelled a lot and that in-

spired him to capture the life and culture of Jerusalem, Paris, Lisbon, Singapore, Berlin, Frankfurt, Tokyo and New York. "Some of my favourite works have been done while on these jaunts..." he says. But Mario's life in Goa and Mumbai is irresistible. It is autobiographical—his experiences of childhood, weddings, funerals, Bombay-Goa passenger ships, the village band, the spirit of Mumbai...all that is nostalgic. See it all in the 8,000 specimens compiled in this book.